

THE WEAK AND THE STRONG

ANN AND BETH: HOUSEWIVES AND DAUGHTERS

Ann is thirty-five years of age. She is the younger daughter of a couple we'll call Robert and Ruth Jones. Her parents are millionaires. Mr. Jones owns and operates several businesses in the distribution industry. Mrs. Jones is a traditional housewife. She never completed college and has never been employed outside the home. She is, however, active in several noble causes in her community. When her children were young, she served on the PTA.

Her daughter Ann is very candid about her relationship with her parents:

It would be so easy ... to take money from my parents ... for the house, ... for private school tuition.... But it always comes with strings.... My sister [Beth, age thirty-seven] learned that.... She does not lead her own life.... She has learned that the dole comes with a price ... do it Mother's way.

Ann understood the components of the parental control equation early on. When she was first married, she and her husband sought employment out of town. She insulated herself from her parents' influence by putting more than one thousand miles between herself and them.

Ann gave up her own career after her second child was born. But unlike her sister, Beth, Ann never accepted economic outpatient care from her parents. Ann became sensitive to the real cost of being on the dole by observing her sister's experience.

According to Ann, Beth and her family live in "subsidized housing." Mr. and Mrs. Jones made a sizable down payment on Beth's home. They also dole out thousands of dollars to Beth each year for housing and other expenses. She receives \$20,000 in cash from her parents every